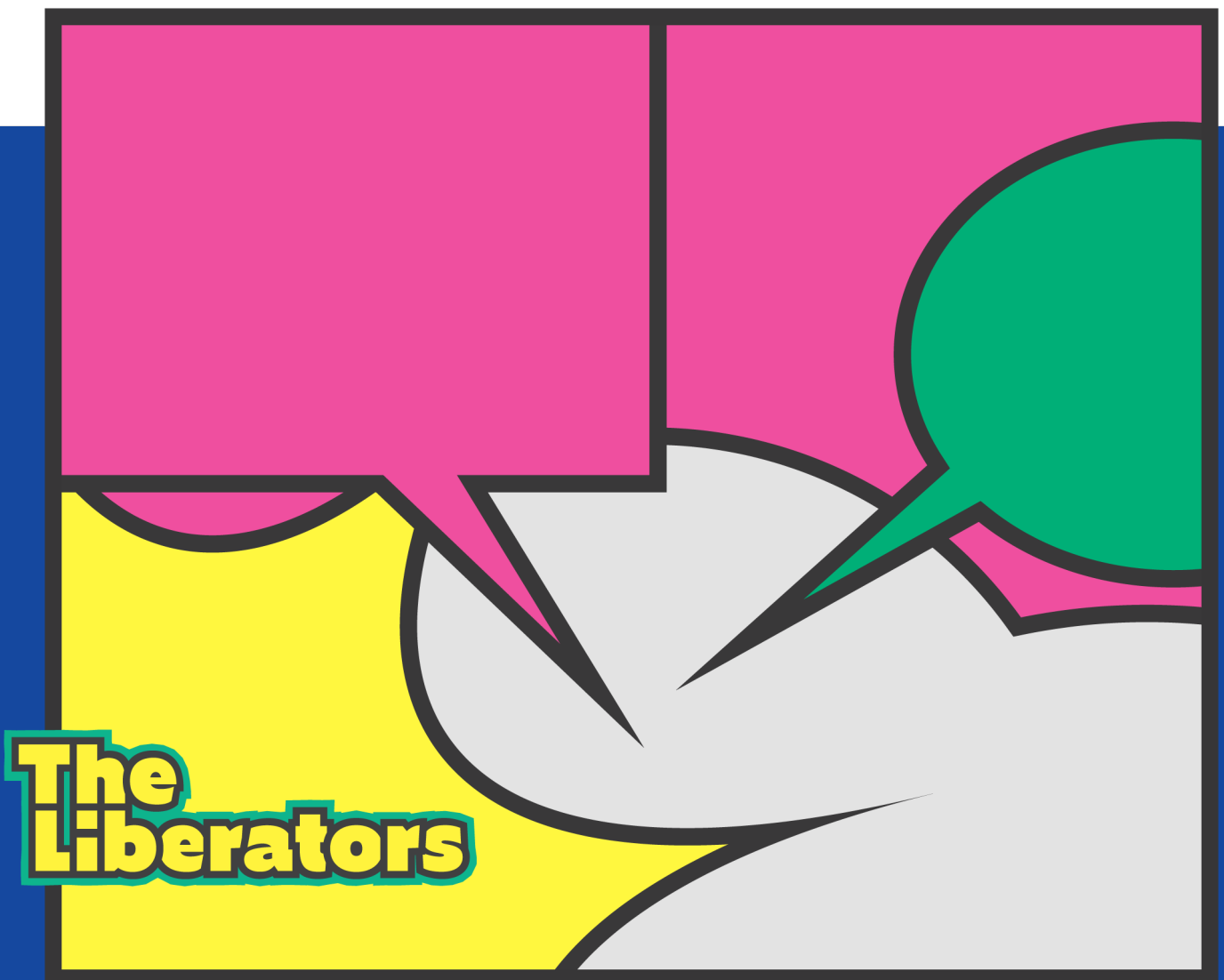


Product Kit: Unleash Scrum In Your Organization

The product kit "Unleash Scrum In Your Organization" includes material to diagnose Scrum in your organization and unleash the potential of all Scrum teams. This paper describes how to use the included exercises.



Hey There, Scrum Practitioner!

Scrum impacts the entire organization. To unlock your Scrum team's superpowers, improvements are necessary within and especially around teams. We created this kit to help see the bigger picture. It's filled with materials to diagnose Scrum in your organization and unleashes its potential with Scrum.

The materials in this kit are based on our ongoing scientific investigation with the ['Scrum Team Survey'](#). By analyzing data from over 7.000 teams, we identified five core factors that distinguish effective from less effective Scrum teams. We also identified over 20 lower-order factors. This kit includes two posters that summarize the core findings and should make it easy to use an evidence-based approach to Scrum.

The beating heart of this kit is "Panarchy". It is the most powerful way we know to collaboratively analyze the system in and around Scrum teams. With the Impediment cards, you can visualize where support is needed. It isn't always easy to transition from knowing where the problems are to getting the help you need from the people who can give it. So we included "What I Need From You" to drive these conversations. We also included a huge stack of Quick Tips that we created with our community. Even in environments where everything seems stuck, these cards provide many practical and simple ways to trigger big change through many small steps. You can capture all these improvements on the 15% Solutions blocks we included.

This facilitation guide offers a description of how to use these exercises in-person and/or online. You can run these exercises separately, or combined in one larger workshop. Whatever you prefer and what makes sense for your organization. As such, you can unleash your Scrum team's superpowers anywhere, anytime!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Material & Resources

Group Size

This exercise takes between 90 and 120 minutes, depending on group size. You can easily divide the workshop into separate sessions if you don't have that time.

Intended Audience

This kit is designed to analyze the system in and around Scrum teams. So don't limit the participants to just the teams themselves, but work hard to include people who are important to the teams. Two groups are particularly critical to include. The first are the "stakeholders" of the teams, like users, customers, and other people who have a clear stake in what the teams create. The second is the "supporters", like managers, leaders, and external coaches. The outcomes and the impediments you identify will affect and benefit them equally.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Material

The product kit "Unleash Scrum In Your Organization" contains the following (physical and/or virtual) materials:

- The exercise "Panarchy" to diagnose Scrum in your organization. You help Scrum teams, stakeholders, and supporters understand how their system works and find leverage points for improvement.
- The exercise "What I Need From You". It helps Scrum teams to clearly express their needs and for others to clearly respond to those requests. This sidesteps the corporate jargon that often muddies such requests, and is essential for groups to be successful. The exercise includes a 100-sheet block of tearable 'help request cards'.
- A card deck with 102 Quick Tips to improve your Scrum team. We categorized them into the factors you also find in the Scrum Team Survey. This exercise encourages you to trigger big change by starting small.
- 5 Impediment cards. Impediments are problems the team can't resolve themselves. Use these 5 impediment cards to make visible where you're stuck and need support from others to improve the situation.
- A 50-sheet block of tearable 15% Solution-cards. Ready to be filled out by members of your team.
- "[What makes Scrum teams effective?](#)". This digital poster offers a nice, visual overview of the core findings from our scientific investigation into what makes Scrum teams effective.
- Poster: "[Factors that determine Scrum team effectiveness](#)". This digital poster offers an overview of all the 20+ factors that determine a Scrum team's effectiveness.

Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Tool: [Scrum Team Survey](#)
- Book: [Zombie Scrum Survival Guide](#)
- Scientific paper: [A Theory of Scrum Team Effectiveness](#)



Flow

Step 1: Opening

 5 min

Step 2: Explore The Foundations Of Effective Scrum Teams

  20 min

Step 3: Diagnose Scrum In Your Organization With Panarchy

  90 min

Step 4: Use Quick Tips To Identify Improvements

  20 min

Step 5: Clearly Express Essential Needs With "What I Need From You"

  45 min

Total duration

 180 min



Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then introduce the purpose and start with the first step. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in. Set the expectation that it's going to be an interactive workshop with lots of opportunities to share and learn from each other.





Step 2: Explore The Foundations Of Effective Scrum Teams

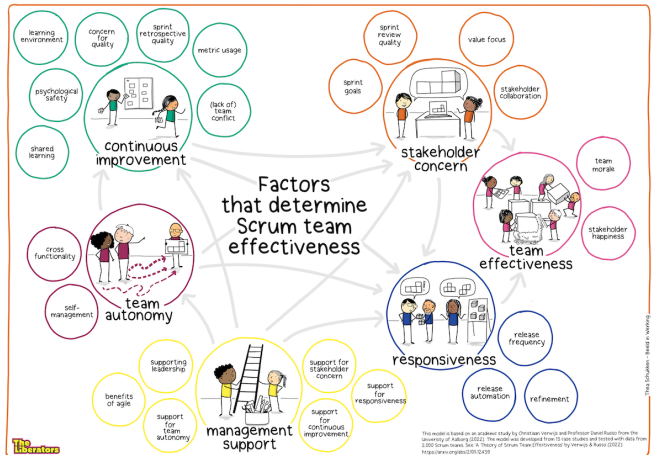
Before you dive into the core exercise "Panarchy", it is useful to investigate the research that drives it first. The Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) is a great way to do this together, interactively.

Steps

- 1 min** Prepare by putting the posters on the wall or in a digital workspace. Make sure that everyone can clearly see and read the posters. Bring more copies if necessary.
- 4 min** Invite everyone to silently review the posters.
- 1 min** Ask: "In silence and individually, identify the two things from the posters that seem most meaningful or impactful to you".
- 2 min** Invite people to pair up with one other person and share their takeaways. Set up breakout rooms if you do this virtually. Ask: "In your pair, share your biggest insights and build on them together".
- 4 min** Invite the pairs to pair up with another pair to form groups of four as much as possible. Ask: "In your small groups, share your biggest insights and build on them together".
- 10 min** With the whole group, collect the most critical insights and questions. Try to answer the questions by putting your insights together.

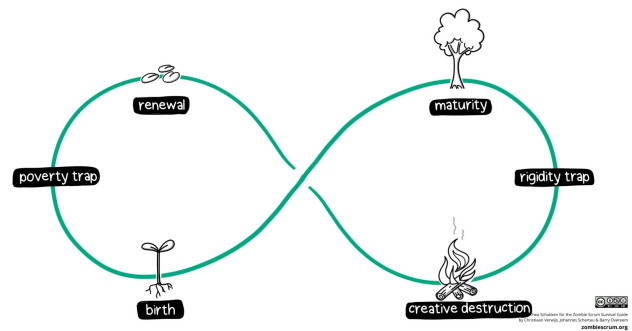
Resources

- Blog post: [In-Depth: What Makes Scrum Teams Effective?](#)
- Academic paper: [A Theory Of Scrum Team Effectiveness](#)
- Poster: ["What makes Scrum teams effective?"](#)
- Poster: ["Factors that determine Scrum team effectiveness"](#)
- 1-2-4-ALL: the [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: [Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with 1-2-4-ALL](#)



Panarchy & Ecocycle Planning: A Metaphor From Nature

Organizations are complex systems. They are made up of many layers, components, and elements that interact in unexpected and unpredictable ways. This interplay guides and shapes our behavior and what is possible. Systems Thinking offers a perspective on how we can influence complex systems. It invites us to look for patterns in the entire system and identify potential leverage points. Once we find the proper leverage points, even a small push can trigger a big change.



The purpose of this Liberating Structure is to help Scrum teams, stakeholders, and supporters understand how their system works, and to find and identify improvements. Rather than doing this alone or with a small group, the complexity is exactly why you want to include as many perspectives as possible. This exercise helps your Scrum team(s), stakeholders, and their supporters to diagnose, inspect, and improve how to use Scrum more effectively.

This exercise comes with more than 20 factors, like "Refinement", "Psychological Safety" and "Responsiveness". Together with your team, stakeholders and supporters, you plot them on the Ecocycle where you think they are:

- **Renewal** represents all the factors that you believe to be important, but that you haven't begun investing in with concrete actions.
- **Birth** represents the factors that you have just started investing in with concrete actions. The more you invest in them, the more mature this factor will become eventually.
- **Maturity** represents the factors that you feel are mature. It doesn't take much conscious effort or discipline to practice them.
- **Creative Destruction** represents all factors where the practices to keep them alive have become stale and boring. Factors in this category require re-invention or re-discovery of how to practice them well.

All factors flow through the Ecocycle. But they can also get stuck. Factors that you know are important but are never invested in, get stuck in the **Poverty Trap**. Factors that you keep doing, but aren't really adding any value any longer, are in the **Rigidity Trap**. By plotting all factors across the Ecocycle, you can identify patterns that tell you something about where you are as a team. Look for the following patterns in particular:

- A healthy Ecocycle is balanced. There is innovation taking place, as evidenced by factors on the left of the model, and there are factors that are mature, as evidenced by items on the right. Furthermore, teams are continuously reinventing how to do things and become better, as represented in what is in Creative Destruction.
- Factors that are in the Rigidity Trap and Creative Destruction are prime candidates for reinvention in how they are practiced. For example, you may discover that the way you do "Refinement" is ineffective, and you need to creatively destroy how you do it.



Step 3: Diagnose Scrum In Your Organization With Panarchy

In the previous step, you introduced the Scrum Team Effectiveness Model. Now that the group has a basic understanding of the various factors, it's a good moment to start with the Liberating Structure "Panarchy".

Preparation

1. Invite your Scrum team(s), stakeholders, and supporters. By supporters, we mean people from the supporting organization, like management, external coaches, and so on.
2. Create large, shared Ecocycle Plannings on the floor or the wall, or in a virtual workspace. We recommend one for each Scrum team, one for the stakeholders, and one for the supporters. You can also combine all Scrum teams in a single Ecocycle if you're more interested in patterns across teams.
3. Use the Ecocycle Planning cards to mark the various quadrants of the Ecocycles.
4. Provide every Ecocycle with a full set of cards with the various factors that match their role (Scrum team, stakeholder, or supporters). Also, give each Scrum team a set of impediment cards.
5. If you don't have enough, either make copies or put them somewhere visible so people can copy them (or just the unique identifiers on the cards).
6. Bring empty pieces of paper or hand out notebooks so people can draw an Ecocycle for themselves.

How to run this exercise online?

- In a virtual session, you can use a virtual whiteboard like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#) to provide a similar experience. You can set up your canvas as shown in the screenshot. If you have multiple groups, copy the canvas a couple of times so that each group has its own canvas and sets of events and activities.
- Use breakout rooms to move the conversations into smaller groups. Our preference is to change a 1-2-4-ALL into a 1-3-ALL. This is way simpler to arrange.
- Download the set of factors for Scrum teams, stakeholders, and supporters (PDF). Make sure to have enough copies of the set (virtual or physical) so that you can divide the total group of participants into small groups, each with its own set.

Steps

1. **5 min** Introduce Ecocycle Planning. Explain the metaphor, and the quadrants and give some examples to help people understand how it works, roughly.
2. **5 min** Introduce the three types of cards with the various factors. There's a different set for Scrum teams, stakeholders, and supporters. Provide the groups at each Ecocycle with a set of relevant cards. So each Scrum teams get a set of cards for "Scrum team", the group of stakeholders gets a set of cards for "Stakeholder" and the group of supporters gets a set of cards for "Supporter". Also, provide everyone with an empty piece of paper.
3. **15 min** Invite everyone to draw an Ecocycle on their piece of paper for personal reflection. Give them time to silently distribute the factors across their drawn Ecocycle based on where they think they are for their Scrum team. Stakeholders and supporters create an Ecocycle based on the Scrum teams they work the closest with and/or know most about.
4. **10 min** Then, invite the people at each Ecocycle to share their reflections and to place the factors from the set they received on their shared Ecocycle to reflect those patterns. So if most people put "Refinement" in "Maturity" in their personal Ecocycle, then place it there in the shared Ecocycle for this group. Encourage people not to overthink it; we're looking for broad patterns.
5. **10 min** Now, use a quick "1-2-4-ALL" to ask the people in each group to reflect on their group's Ecocycle. Ask: "What do you notice about the distribution of factors in our Ecocycle? What jumps out?". You can help draw out patterns by noticing where most cards of one color appear, whether or not the Ecocycle is balanced and which items appear in the traps.

6. **5 min** Then, invite the Scrum teams to use the "Impediment" cards to mark the 3 factors that are most impeded for their team. A factor is impeded when there are blockades or problems that make it hard for them to do well on this factor, but that lies outside of their control to resolve. In the meantime, the stakeholders and supporters can continue their conversation from step 5 if they want.
7. **10 min** Now it's time for shared reflection. Invite everyone to step back and look at all the Ecocycles that were created. While they walk around, ask everyone to silently reflect on how the levels might interact: "What patterns do you see across the Ecocycles? Where do the levels connect, strengthen, or impede?".
8. **15 min** Then, use "1-2-4-ALL" to invite people to identify opportunities for change across levels. Ask: "Where do you see opportunities for the patterns in one Ecocycle to strengthen or reinforce those in another? Where can the elements of one Ecocycle positively disrupt what is happening elsewhere?". Capture the most salient opportunities with the whole group.
9. **15 min** Now, use a final "1-2-4-ALL" to capture improvement actions. Ask "What actions can we take immediately to invest in these opportunities?". Ask each group to share the 2 or 3 most promising and actionable ideas with the whole group.
10. Optionally, you can use a Liberating Structure like "Shift & Share", "1-2-4-ALL" or "15% Solutions" to develop action plans to work on the selected items.

Our findings

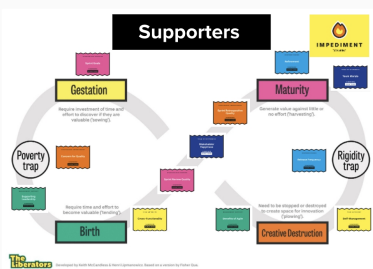
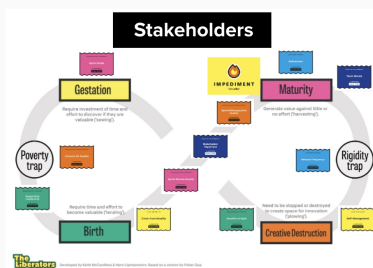
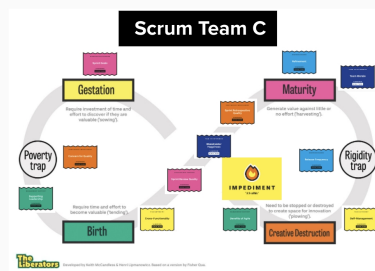
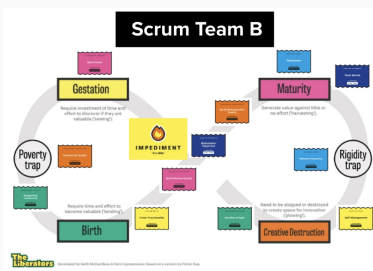
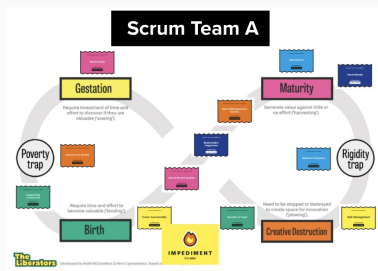
Optionally, as part of step 3, present the group six prompts for everyone to complete on their Ecocycle Planning illustration. After each prompt, pause to give them time to write down their answer in the specified quadrant, with their current team in mind or the team they work closest with.

- Top-left (Gestation): "A factor that my team is unaware of or hasn't started using is..."
- Bottom-left (Birth): "A factor my team recently started using or investing time in is..."
- Top-right (Maturity): "A factor that provides lots of value for my team is..."
- Bottom-right (Creative Destruction): "A factor we are currently rethinking, changing, or creatively destructing is..."
- Middle left (Poverty Trap): "A factor, we consider valuable, talk about a lot, but somehow don't invest enough time in is..."
- Middle right (Rigidity Trap): "A factor, we keep doing, despite we know it doesn't generate much value anymore is..."

Resources

- Blog post: [Apply Systems Thinking With Panarchy](#)
- Blog post: [Panarchy on LiberatingStructures.com](#)







Steps

- ## Our Findings

- ## Resources

- The original article on [15% Solutions](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Trigger BIG change by starting small with ["15% Solutions"](#)
- Blog post: [The Fine Art Of Making Your Improvements Actionable](#)
- Blog post: [How To Refine Your Improvements Into Actionable Quick Tips?](#)



Step 5: Clearly Express Essential Needs With "What I Need From You"

We often need help from others to change how we work. But it's hard for others to help if you don't clearly express what it is you need from them. It's easy to get stuck in vague requests like "We need to communicate openly", or "I need your support". No wonder the response to these needs is often equally vague, like "I will do my best", or "We'll see". Unclear requests for help are often met with equally unclear commitments.

The Liberating Structure "What I Need From You" (WINFY), helps groups to clearly express their needs and for others to clearly respond to those requests. This sidesteps the corporate jargon that often muddies such requests. We find it essential for groups of people that have to work together to be successful.

You may find that interactions in this structure are quite direct or even blunt. But WINFY is designed as an antidote to the diffusion of accountability that is prevalent in organizations and gets in the way of success.

You can use WINFY as a separate workshop, but it's also perfectly suited to run after Panarchy and the Quick Tips exercise. With Panarchy, you create transparency about Scrum in your organization and the impediments teams face. The Quick Tips are potential improvements to remove these impediments. WINFY allows everyone to clearly express essential needs in order to actually make these improvements happen.



Invitation

"What do you need from others in this room to be even more successful in achieving our shared purpose?
Where do you need help to strengthen success factors or remove impediments?"

Steps

1. Invite your teams and everyone who impacts the success of your work together. Either virtually or in a physical room, let people organize into their functional groups. So all members of a team remain together, but so do the people from sales, management, the stakeholders, external coaches, and so on. Make sure everyone present knows which groups are present by letting each group announce themselves (e.g. "We are sales", "We are Scrum team A", and so on).
2. **2 min** Ask everyone to first individually write down one or more clear functional requests they have to other groups in this room. You can give some examples, like "As a Scrum team, we need management to stop changing our composition without our approval" or "As management, we need the Scrum teams to tell us openly what is impeding their work".
3. **10 min** Invite everyone to share their best ideas within their functional groups. Each group works together to capture their most important 3 to 5 functional requests on the placeholder cards that come with this set. If you do this virtually, move each functional group into a breakout.
4. **1 min** Ask each functional group to designate one representative and gather them in the middle of the room. If you're doing this virtually, everyone else turns off their microphone.
5. **10 min** One by one, each representative addresses the representative from another functional group they have a request for, and announce it. For example: "From management, we need the learning budget to be doubled for this quarter" or "From Scrum team A, we need one person who is willing to share these findings with higher management". When a need is announced to a group, its representative takes note but doesn't answer. Block any

discussion, even when the request is unclear.

6. **5 min** When all requests have been made, the representatives return to their groups and decide on their answer to each request. Three responses are possible: "Yes", "No", "Whatever (Your request is too unclear)".
7. **10 min** The representatives gather in the circle again. One by one, they repeat the requests that were made to their group and share the answer of their group. Again, there is no discussion and no elaboration. If the answer was "No", the group asking for it can trust that their request won't happen. If it was "Yes", then the group asking it can be certain that it will happen. If the response was "Whatever", the request was too unclear.

Our findings

- Depending on the situation you can do additional rounds of making requests and giving answers. The goal is to make (painfully) clear how crucial it is to be specific when asking for help, as unclear requests and unclear commitments are a sign of ineffective Scrum. Do another round when you are certain that not being able to ask new requests causes more harm than the learning of not being able to ask again.
- Some tension during this experiment is natural as groups express clear requests and (finally) get clear answers. Recognize and accept it when it happens. Encourage participants to continue communicating their needs outside of this gathering using the same format. If a request was not understood or denied, try asking differently.
- If you see members of a group complaining about and blaming other people, ask them what it is they need specifically and whether they have communicated this need adequately.

Resources

- Blog post: ["Clearly express essential needs across groups with "What I Need From You"](#)
- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website



After The Exercise

The workshop in this facilitation guide gives you a good opportunity to diagnose how Scrum is going in your organization. It should make it easier to unleash the potential of your Scrum teams. Please share your experiences with us – we love to hear about them. And we're always available for questions and support.

Learn and grow, together!

Try Our Other Product Kits

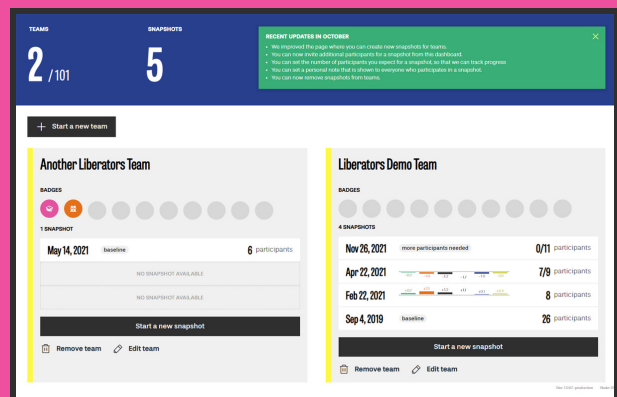
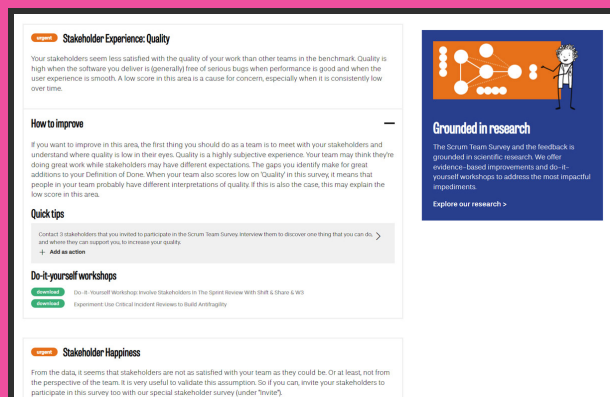
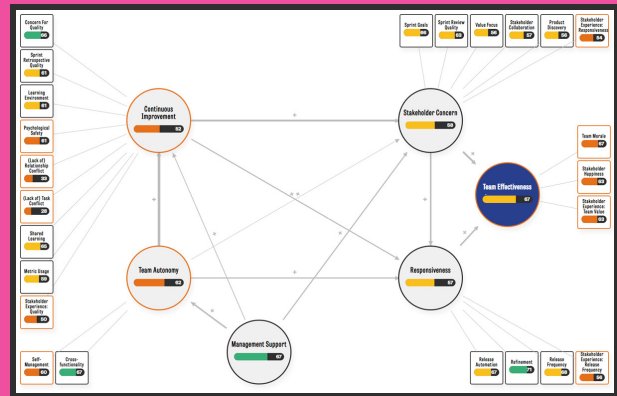
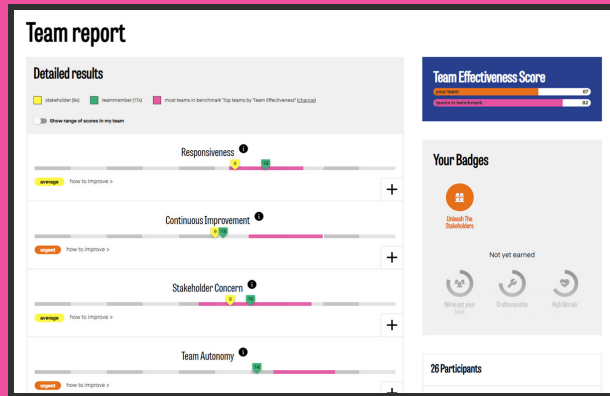
We like to take a hands-on and highly interactive approach with all the teams we work with. This has led to the creation of many exercises and materials that you can also benefit from. Go to our webshop at shop.theliberators.com to find all of them. Each exercise is carefully designed to include all voices.

In addition to this kit, we have two other kits you may like. The [Scrum Team Starter Kit](#) is great for new Scrum teams or teams that wish to refresh their collaboration. The [Zombie Scrum First Aid Kit](#) is excellent to create urgency by testing how much Zombie Scrum may be going on in your organization.



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Maintain one or many teams from a single dashboard		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Insights		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

info@scrumteamsurvey.org

Unleashing Teams All Over The World

We are The Liberators – Barry Overeem and Christiaan Verwijs. Our mission is to create data-driven products to unleash the superpowers of teams all over the world. We do this together with a growing community of patrons.

Awesome content for awesome teams

We unleash teams with our [blogposts](#), our [podcast](#), our [newsletter](#), our [videos](#), and our frequent [meetups](#). While we offer most of this for free, we also have plenty of premium content in [our webshop](#) for you to explore.

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